Birds of a feather

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Birds of a feather

by Lilliae

Summary

"But why are your wings exposed? Already needed elsewhere?"

"I was merely preening them."

Phainon blinked. "As in… grooming them?"

The same way Mydei brushed his hair or straightened his clothes. But his wings?

"What's with that look? Surely you…" Mydei realised, so affronted yet resigned for it, "You never preened your wings."

"Well they—they're divine wings! Forged from the power of the Coreflames that inhabit my body. Why would they need *preening?"*

"Does that divine body of yours need no washing either?"

In the millions of cycles Phainon's wings had sprouted and smouldered at his back, wing care had never occurred to him. They were simply there—nothing more and nothing less.

The same cannot be said for Mydei, who diligently cares for his body and is determined to instil the same practice into Phainon.

Notes

I know Mydei and Phainon's wings aren't "proper" wings when you look at them. But I don't care because wing fic! The world needs more wing fics!!

See the end of the work for more notes

Over the past few years, Phainon had become accustomed to late mornings in someone's arms or early mornings to someone bustling in the kitchen. Then returning in the evening to the warm glow of the hearth from someone already home or lighting it himself and waiting, in the kitchen, in the andron, to hear the front door open.

For the past two weeks, there had been no one to greet him with a small smile, so subtle Phainon could only be proud that he was privy to it, and an embrace so tender it was as though neither had ever known the roughness of a fist or sharpness of a blade. Despite the real sun shining bright over Amphoreus, life in Okhema had never been so dull. It was only natural with Mydei away in Castrum Kremnos.

They messaged each other every morning about mundane things—how did you sleep? What are you eating for breakfast? What are your plans today? Do you miss me like I miss you?—and spoke every night over teleslate. If their afternoons were both spent on paperwork then they usually left a call running, tethering them together through paper rustling and pens scratching without the need to speak.

Fortunately his suffering was soon to end. Mydei would be returning to Okhema within the next few days. The sheer excitement would have kept him awake through the night, if only his workload hadn't done so already.

Despite starting as a calculation from a machine well-informed on the greater universe Amphoreus' citizens had been shut away from, Amphoreus' natural daylight cycle differed from the universe's standardised system hours.

Since Cerydra had journeyed beyond the stars for diplomatic meetings, along with an entourage of warriors led by Hysilens, her free time often didn't align with Amphoreus' waking hours. As such, Anaxa, Aglaea, Mydei and Phainon had been awake in one big conference call—stretched across Amphoreus' hills and valleys, and the expanse of stars and planets—until the early hours of the morning.

The marketplace had already begun to hum with the vendors setting up their storefronts when Phainon stumbled home from the designated "war room" in Marmoreal Palace; named as such after Cerydra overruled Aglaea's suggestion to call it the "council room".

He hardly had the energy to kick off his shoes. It was only Mydei's voice echoing in his head, telling him not to be so sloppy with hygiene, to take care of himself and his belongings, that got his shoes and coat off before he crashed onto the kline.

It still carried Mydei's scent. The natural oils that rose from his heated skin as he slept were beginning to fade under the perfumed scents, usually found on Mydei himself, that Phainon had taken to lightly applying onto the sheets.

It was a complete facsimile of Mydei's presence, missing his underlying scent, his great warmth that never transgressed into something scorching, his little huff of laughter when Phainon nudged his way into the crook of his neck. But it was the closest thing to Mydei within his grasp and Phainon nuzzled his nose into the sheets with heavy eyelids.

As the day's first light slipped in through the open curtains, he allowed himself to pretend that Mydei had rolled out of bed just for a moment. That he left a light kiss on Phainon's forehead and a whisper of where he was going, so quiet Phainon missed everything except the promise Mydei would be here once he next awoke.

A perfect little dream that carried onwards with the scent of firewood and fresh food wafting through the house. His body followed the motions of crawling from the kline and out into the main house before his sluggish mind could dispel the haze of sleep made more burdensome by his persistent exhaustion.

When he shuffled into the andron, Mydei was already right where he was supposed to be. The only intruder on the domestic scene were the six wings extending from his back. They were divine in the afternoon sunlight: the feathers shimmered like they were forged from delicate plates of gold, dusted in it, and then smouldered all down the feathery expanse. Akin to flames licking down his wings, the gold seared until it darkened into a richer, deeper gradient down to the crimson ends.

Even loosely curled around him, they were large. *Powerful.* Strong enough for Mydei to soar across Amphoreus like a red-tailed comet even with Phainon in his arms. The six wings obscured Mydei's back but Phainon knew well enough, had memorised long ago, the tantalising lines of Mydei's back muscles at work.

Phainon blinked. Then rubbed his eyes crusted and blurred with sleep. Mydei remained on the kline. It really was a dream to wake up after an arduous night and find his husband waiting for him, bathed in resplendent gold and sunlight. Less a God of Strife than the embodiment of the ordinary life they stood as vanguard to defend.

Food forgotten, he padded into the andron and feathers bristled as Mydei sensed his presence with instincts honed for war, braced for the possibility of being outflanked, ambushed, stabbed in the back. Mydei didn't turn to greet him as he slumped over the kline and fell between the sprouted ridges of bone and muscle. He nuzzled his face against the supple skin of Mydei's back.

Spiced pomegranates and an underlying floral scent. His mouth watered with the urge to bite, to taste for himself whether a burst of tart sweetness or the metallic tang of blood would fill his mouth, but he only wrapped his arms around Mydei's waist and snuggled his cheek into his nape. The position was hardly comfortable but he closed his eyes and let himself be lulled into a deeper sleep by this lovely dream he hoped became reality within the next few days.

"What are you doing?" Mydei's voice rumbled from his chest into Phainon's cheek, rattling around his brain.

"Sleeping. Hush."

"You've only just roused from sleep."

His only response was a long drawn out hum as he snuggled closer. The kline's curve dug into his stomach and his back protested at the angle he had folded himself into, clinging onto Mydei without putting pressure on his wings. Regardless, he had no intention of moving

when it was Mydei's scent, his real one, hidden beneath the sweet pomegranates, wafting up his nose.

"Even you're not so impressive you can fall asleep in such a position."

Again, Phainon only hummed. It trailed off into a sigh more than anything else as his breathing evened out and his body, down to his vocal cords, relaxed.

"Phainon," he said so slowly, annunciating every syllable as though he needed to beat Phainon over the head with his own name, "you're already awake."

His eyes opened to ruddy skin betraying an embarrassment unheard within his voice, carefully suppressing any lost composure beneath exasperation. "I am?" A sharp pinch stung his cheeks and he flinched back but Mydei's bare fingers were unyielding even as he yelped, "I am! I am!"

At his coerced acquiescence, Mydei released him and finally craned his head back over his shoulder. His upper wing hid the lower half of his face but there was no mistaking the expert combination of exasperation and fondness that only Mydei could pull off. Others came close but it was the crease of Mydei's eyes and Mydei's subdued, crooked smile that made the heat rise to his face from his heart.

Mydei had just enough time to twist around before Phainon's dispensed with the last vestiges of sleep and threw himself into Mydei's awaiting arms. They tumbled onto the kline, hands hiting the mattress to hold himself aloft and take in the sight of Mydei below.

Mydei's immaculate braid held by red and blue bejewelled clasp Phainon had bought him. Mydei's earring and necklace glittering in the sunlight that slipped around Phainon's looming shadow. Mydei's eyes like a dawn that rose for Phainon alone.

The wings curled around him in prelude to Mydei's arms folding him into a proper embrace, tugging him down so his ear landed against Mydei's bare chest. Despite his stoic facade, softening at its sternest edges, Mydei's heart beat as rapidly as his own.

Mydei's natural scent was accompanied by the cool, crisp air found at the high altitudes Mydei ascended to during flight in the hopes of avoiding any panic in those who happened to witness the embodiment of Strife rushing across distant lands. It was proof Mydei had hurried back from Castrum Kremnos so the lines of their bodies could meld together as though they had never been apart.

Phainon's head lurched up. "The meeting… did you rest at all before departing Castrum Kremnos?"

It took Mydei several hours to fly between the two cities that had come to house a divided Kremnoan population. Many chose to follow their long held wishes and return to their original homeland, rebuilding it in all the glory that shone in millions of accumulated memories. The same reason of lived familiarity caused just as many to settle in Okhema even without the threat of the world's end closing in upon them.

Until he could entrust the Kremnoan future to themselves and step down in a time of peace and stability, Mydei was responsible for both. But, for the first time, it was an arduous task with the end he hoped for within sight.

As Mydei's frequent companion, Phainon was familiar with the length of the journey. Although it was undoubtedly quicker without Phainon exploiting the excuse to be cradled in Mydei's arms for a few hours, feigning ignorance about his own wings just below the skin, it was impossible to arrive in Okhema by early afternoon assuming he settled down for a few hours of well-deserved rest before departing.

Mydei blinked slowly and answered, straight-faced and unashamed in his disregard when it was his own body and not Phainon's that needed proper care, "No."

"Mydei!"

He pushed off Mydei's chest but soft feathers brushed along his back and he paused before he was fully upright. It left him stooped at an awkward angle because Mydei's wings had cocooned them in: a gold and auburn weave, wheat fields and autumn leaves, speckled with sparse light that filtered through the gaps between his feathers. Phainon was too weak to disrupt the serene embrace akin to lying beneath the trees overhanging the wheat fields.

Instead he held Mydei down with two resolute hands on his chest. The firm muscles and supple skin tempted his splayed fingers to squeeze but he resisted, pushing down the heat rising to his cheeks so he could maintain a serious, commanding gaze down his nose.

"Hold yourself to the same standards you hold me. Before I start announcing to all who will listen about what a hypocrite my husband turned out to be."

Mydei snorted. "Something else for you to be my equal in." The retort was much too light to contain much snark. "There's a saying in Castrum Kremnos: Strife never sleeps."

Fitting for a military fortress that roamed Amphoreus in search of lands to conquer and cities to carve up, always seeking out the next roar of Nikador's thunder and flames. Even as the winters halted their campaigns, the forges burned in ceaseless preparation for the year to come.

Phainon leaned to set more weight upon Mydei's chest, hitching beneath his palms when Phainon stooped to nudge their foreheads together, eyes closed but knowing the sight of Mydei's wide ones by memory. "I'm not speaking of Strife. I'm talking about you, Mydei."

In the same manner Mydei spoke of *Phainon.* Not the Worldbearer, nor a being tempered by a golden drop of Destruction. Not even the shining, heroic ideal of the Deliverer that Mydei insisted Phainon had earned—not *in spite* of his many shortcomings, which had required he pass the title and all the hope bound within it onto the Trailblazer. To Mydei those thirty-three million cycles, just as his many deaths and revivals in a given lifetime, weren't failures. They were proof of strength, of endurance, of determination to see something important through to the end—because Mydei had always peered beneath that pretty facade even when he was kind enough, for Phainon's sake, to pretend there was nothing more to see.

They were hypocrites. Both of them. The first to tell others to stand back while they charged ahead. The first to advocate the value of another's life while spilling their own blood in service of something greater than themselves. Perhaps it should have been infuriating for two people with the same bad habit to come together. For them, it simply meant they understood each other best.

The urge to protect. The urge to destroy. The urge to love a body, a mind, a person in the hopes its owner would learn to love themselves more in turn.

Pushed upon his back, Myde's hair fell away to expose the red tips of his ears. His throat bobbed and his eyes slid away but were so quick to come back again, confronting Phainon's honesty with his own. "I… will keep that in mind. Next time." The flush spread down from his ears to his cheeks. "I simply wanted to return to your side sooner."

How was Phainon supposed to argue against that when the slightest mention of Mydei missing him, their home, as much as Phainon missed having Mydei within it, made him grin uncontrollably.

"Welcome home," he murmured with all the emotions unwinding from his heart to give to Mydei. They belonged to him after all. "But why are your wings exposed? Already needed elsewhere?"

It was difficult to keep the disappointment from his voice at the prospect of Mydei departing again. It used to be such a simple thing, to mould himself into what the people needed to see. But he had become accustomed to being so unapologetically himself around Mydei, who wouldn't wholeheartedly accept anything else, that he was no longer certain how to be empty when there was so much Mydei wanted to see and Phainon was willing to show him.

His dismay lifted at the shake of Mydei's head. "I was merely preening them."

Preening.

Phainon blinked. "As in… grooming them?"

The same way Mydei brushed his hair or straightened his clothes. But his wings?

Mydei's brows furrowed, nose wrinkling. "What's with that look? Surely you…"

Then his face settled into its usual stoicism, like disturbed sediment back to the riverbed. A near blank, tranquil mask if not for the obvious disapproval shadowing his eyes.

"You never preened your wings," Mydei realised, so affronted yet resigned for it.

Despite the absurdity of Mydei's incredulity, Phainon's cheeks heated as though he were truly in the wrong. "Well they—they're divine wings! Forged from the power of the Coreflames that inhabit my body. Why would they need *preening?"*

Mydei kissed his teeth. "Does that divine body of yours need no washing either?"

"Well, technically…"

The answer was yes. At least when his form was closer to divine than human. A time when his body temperature was so high it scorched his eyes to a blind dryness and all the possible dirt that could sully his so-called flawless vessel. Blood, both red and gold, evaporated as easily as his tears.

But Mydei's lips were set in a stern line along the boundary of a frown and a scowl, and they had been so many things to each other over such a long time that Phainon knew enough to silence himself. He smiled.

The pat against his cheek was a touch too condescending as Mydei sighed, "Sit on the floor."

Phainon leaned into Mydei's palm, head tilting in silent question, but Mydei didn't elaborate beyond the expectant arch of his brow. Although Mydei had commanded he extricate himself from their embrace, his wings remained stubbornly huddled around them; hesitant to part until Phainon slipped his finger between the soft seams between overlapping feathers. They immediately opened, petals blooming at dawn, and Phainon got to his feet.

"In front of the window," Mydei commanded while he rolled off the kline and took two cushions with him. He tossed them onto the ground and Phainon began to sit but Mydei snagged the scruff of his shirt. "Off."

"How scandalous," Phainon remarked with a small, innocent chuckle. The kind that goaded Mydei into some sort of retort. A clumsy attempt at normalcy when he was utterly lost and blindly following Mydei's whims. There were worse places to be.

He tugged his shirt overhead and Mydei beckoned with his hand, taking the shirt from him before folding it nearly and setting it aside on the kline. Phainon pointed at the cushions and Mydei nodded, allowing him to sit.

Mydei knelt upon the cushion behind him. "Release your wings."

That command made Phainon hesitate more than the others. Instinctual; the way peopled stared at the sun only to flinch away. Mydei didn't rush him, giving him the time and space to calm hackling old instincts.

Obediently, Phainon reached for the power dwelling with him, once so hot it had charred his body to ash but now smouldered like embers waiting for him to drop the fresh spark that transformed it into a roaring inferno.

The bones and nerves at his shoulder blades twinged first, followed by the pull of skin opening and muscles stretching.

At first he had been hesitant to expose this version of himself to the light of the true dawn; all too eager to leave it and everything he had done in the past where no one would be forcefully reminded of his every terrible transgression. That instinct still reared itself, more feelings than the thoughts that came moments later to soothe that wild, bucking state of panic into something capable of being held.

Although initially exposed by accident, Mydei had come to touch his wings numerous times since. There was no part of Phainon that didn't belong to Mydei, if only he asked.

That included this part of himself he despised. This part of himself he accepted as necessity. As the source of strength that had sustained him through the eternal cycles whilst ravaging the body he whittled down to kindling and let burn to ash.

The only time he could blaze brighter than the sun and be charred by it and still feel human for it was beneath Mydei's hands. So his wings sprouted from his back and he flexed the heavy muscle snared around hollow bones, arching high above him as the feathers opened and cast long, ominous shadows across the room.

Then relaxed in a dry rustle to lay slack between them both. His back had already begun to heat where the wings emerged from his shoulder blades, yet Mydei pressed a kiss between them and his skin prickled like it still recalled the cold. A reward. A reassurance.

He never wanted to be delicate, fragile, one misstep away from shattering where all the fracture lines were long etched into him. For the longest time, even before he first took those twelve Coreflames upon himself, being strong wasn't an option—only a necessity. Do not waver. Do not bend. Do not break until the light of a new dawn for others to enjoy could shine iridescent upon the shards finally permitted to fall apart.

But being delicate wasn't terrible so long as it was Mydei holding him together with care.

His hand pressed flat over the lingering sensation of his lips and Phainon's breath shuddered through him at the sensitivity of the skin melding with feathered joints. That was Mydei's only warning before he dragged his fingertips up the base of one wing and traced across the outer bone to the very tip.

Phainon's wings twitched. Into the touch. Away from it. He couldn't tell.

"I'm going to start," Mydei said, voice low as it passed through his fingers, retracing their path inwards, into Phainon's shifting feathers.

He breathed a weak laugh. "I would say you've already started."

Mydei only hummed because it was retort enough when his finger brushed a long line down the stem of one feather, so light it was almost imperceptible, less than a spring breeze. Since it was Mydei, his shoulders flexed as his wings rose into his touch. His feathers were dry, brittle, as though they would crumble as ash on the wind, yet they glided smoothly through Mydei's fingers as he combed the bristles down to face the neat, tapered point.

He had some scarce experience nurturing birds. A youngling from Aedes Elysiae, a songbird from the Garden of Life, an older messenger bird from the Grove of Epiphany. He was aware of their wing structure and preening habits; it was essential to clear bugs and debris from their wings, to stimulate oils that protected them from the rain, to align their feathers and ensure smooth flight.

“They’re crooked—“ Mydei murmured as he smoothed across Phainon’s marginal coverts at the top and down to his secondary coverts in the centre, “—here.”

There was a sensation he had never truly *felt.* Not until it was Mydei’s voice in his ear and fingers caressing his feathers, telling him that slight annoyance, akin to fabric awkwardly draped and catching across his body, was a feather askew.

“Oh.”

The same moment the awareness set in, the sensation was alleviated by Mydei pinching the feather and shifting it. Then there was a comfortable nothing as the feather seamlessly rejoined the others.

Mydei hummed again but it rumbled with laughter as he combed a set of bristles into a uniform direction. “It feels much better when they’re all in place.”

Methodically, Mydei worked outwards from his scapula and followed the natural layers of feathers. Just as slowly, Phainon became attuned to his own wings. He knew which feathers were crooked, which were overlapping the wrong way, which bristles weren’t folding together neatly, even before Mydei fixed them with gentle, diligent hands.

The state of his wings had never bothered him but his mind had suddenly become aware of every discomfort. It was an itch and his fingers twitched atop his crossed knees with the urge to scratch. But it was Mydei gradually soothing each nuisance into something comfortable rather than simple there.

Once his secondaries were tended to, Mydei followed the bend of his wing out towards his primary coverts. Seated by the window, Phainon was distantly aware of time passing in the shifting light and shadows, yet his open eyes were unseeing as his every attention was re-centred around the physical sensation at his back.

At some point, Mydei finished with his primaries and moved closer to his scapula again, preening at Phainon’s secondary coverts. There was nothing left for him to rectify; if Phainon could feel it then Mydei could certainly see that for himself.

Yet neither of them acknowledged that Mydei’s touch had lost its methodical edge and softened into simple brushes wherever he desired. He no longer groomed Phainon’s feathers so much as he toyed with them. It was equally pleasant. Perhaps more but Phainon would need to accumulate more experience to give an accurate verdict.

Then Mydei’s hand smoothed down his scapula and Phainon jerked upright with a yelp. He whipped around, wings relaxed into a cumbersome deadweight at his back, and Mydei’s hand hovered in the air.

Mydei’s mouth parted, closed, and opened again. “You really are… sensitive there.”

It was an equal revelation for Phainon. He had never spared much attention to his wings. At first they had been novel, as everything had been until it became a drudgery of unending

sameness, but they were too cumbersome to use so he either let them hang as deadweight or dismissed them entirely.

As his core temperature continued to mount with the number of Coreflames within it, no part of his body was safe from the raging inferno. By the time he had become more accustomed to his wings, the feathers were singed dry and the nerves cauterised. It was only Mydei's persistent but gentle touches that slowly retaught them to feel anything at all.

"The down there is short. Let's move on," Mydei said and flicked his chin at Phainon's vacant pillow. A compromise.

Although Phainon loosed a warning glance, to which Mydei rolled his eyes with a playful huff, he rolled his shoulders, stretched his wings with a ruffle of feathers, and reclaimed his seat. True to his word, Mydei ignored the thin skin where they connected to his back as he moved from one wing to the next and repeated the preening process.

From the scapula outwards to the bend of his wing. Down from his secondary coverts to his larger secondary feathers. Scattered among the tender caress that redirected the crooked stems and bristles were the occasional sharp pinches: feathers beyond saving that Mydei plucked free to join a small pile of them. There were less than Phainon expected considering the tragic state of his wings.

He sighed as another one came free, akin to a splinter so small it was hardly even an inconvenience, yet the relief was palpable once it was gone.

"Your feathers lack oil," Mydei murmured, more to himself than Phainon.

Yet he sounded troubled by the notion so Phainon glanced over his shoulder. Only to be greeted by his own feathers, risen into Mydei's touch like a bird's feathers were lifted by the winds. Phainon could imagine the crease to his brow well enough.

"Wait here," Mydei said, fabric rustling as he stood.

He entered Phainon's line of sight as he stepped over to the kline but his six wings obscured the rest of his body until he spun to return. In his hands were the handles of an amphora painted and glazed with blue skies, white clouds and rainbows. Phainon must have been too preoccupied by his husband's sheer presence to notice it on the low table earlier.

"It's cute," Phainon said.

Which wasn't a surprise in itself. Phainon was all too aware, had compiled a mental list in fact, of all the things Mydei did, owned and adored that were cuter than his appearance would lead others to believe. The issue was that Phainon couldn't recall Mydei owning such a thing.

"What's inside?"

Mydei disappeared behind him, his own feathers rustling as they relaxed and dragged across floor while he sat. "Feather oil."

“From where exactly?” Phainon asked with all his skepticism audible.

As amusing as the idea was, he highly doubted Mydei chased down birds to extract oil from their wings.

Ceramic rattled as Mydei lifted the amphora lid, and then clinked when it was set aside. “Hyacine created a formula for Little Ica and is generous enough to make some with a different scent on request.”

“Ah.” The amphora design made a little more sense now.

“I’m starting,” Mydei politely warned, aware Phainon had no objections. When Mydei’s hand returned to his feathers, there was a dampness to them that was left behind with each pass of his fingers—but it wasn’t unpleasant. “Consistent preening should stimulate your feathers to protect themselves with natural oils. But there’s no harm in using extra if needed.”

Mydei’s hand slipped beneath the overlapping rows he had neatened earlier, thoroughly coating from the feathery edges and along the spine to where the stem met his skin before smoothing the layers back down again.

All of his attention had long narrowed down to Mydei’s hands but he closed his eyes as though, behind is eyelids, he could see the outline of slender fingers across dark feathers. “You say that as if this is a frequent hobby of yours.”

“It is.”

Phainon’s wing twitched but Mydei left his secondary feathers for the bend of his wing in a long, sweeping touch meant to calm him. His wings, as tense as the shoulders that carried them, relaxed and Mydei resumed his task.

Eyes still closed, Phainon frowned. “I’ve never seen it. I would have helped you.”

At that, Mydei’s hand paused but Phainon didn’t check if it was ordinary hesitance or something more. Then he resumed his work. “I didn’t want you to feel obligated to reciprocate.”

Obligated to show his wings. To be exposed and vulnerable.

Phainon’s mouth didn’t even bother to part with any objection before they pursed. Mydei knew him much too well. While he was adept at controlling his voice, his expression, and his body language, the part of him exposed to Mydei’s eye was the least cooperative. His wings bristled with too many emotions to name and stood to attention at Mydei’s quiet laugh.

The feather oil settled in a thin coat: viscous enough to avoid dripping but not thick enough to make his feathers claggy and heavy. As Mydei spread more and more across his wings, the scent gathered, warmed by the heat of Mydei’s hands and Phainon’s body, and swirled in the evening breeze through the open window. His nose tickled with the sweetness of spiced pomegranates.

The soothing drag of Mydei's hand lulled his wings to drape as heavy as Phainon's eyelids. It was slow. Almost rhythmic as he caressed the length of one feather and moved onto the next, so similar to Mydei's hand brushing through his hair after a bad memory turned nightmare.

He tried to keep his wings level and ease Mydei's work. But he was surrounded by that familiar scent to be found upon their shared pillows and sheets, while Mydei massaged at Phainon's wings in a steady rhythm even as the muscles began to relax and droop.

Until he swayed and toppled backwards.

His bleary eyes blinked awake. His whole body was draped across Mydei's lap, arms now wrapped around Phainon's waist to catch and keep him there. His wings had fallen slack over Mydei's thighs and arms: feathers straight and glossy and half-intertwined with Mydei's wings curled around them both. Phainon's feathers couldn't compare to Mydei's own but, for the first time in so long, they looked *alive.*

Phainon's tipped his head back and found Mydei already gazing down at him. "We should do this every week."

Upside down, Mydei's lip crooked. "I'll hold you to that."

"I want to do yours too."

Mydei's arms squeezed his waist a final time before he reached to replace the lid on the amphora; a good idea considering how easily their haphazard wing could knock it over. "Later," he promised instead.

Usually, Phainon would pout and goad him a little, perhaps tease. It wasn't as though they had any appointments they urgently needed to keep, so there was no reason for Mydei to deny him. And he wouldn't if Phainon was sincere and persistent enough. Just as Phainon refused Mydei nothing, there was nothing Mydei would deny him.

Instead, Phainon hummed. "You're right."

It was the first sign and only sign something was amiss before he twisted in Mydei's hold and threw his weight forwards. Mydei's wings puffed, shifting to catch them both, but one of Phainon's own was already there, ready, and hit the ground first with them on top. Arms wrapped around each other, wings and feathers gliding together and interlocking, Phainon grinned at Mydei's widened eyes and snuggled closer.

His other wing draped over them and he yawned. "Get some rest. It's been over a full day since you last slept."

"This *cannot* be comfortable for you," Mydei disputed, as though half of his wings weren't laid overtop of Phainon's and supporting their combined weight in a downy mattress.

His feathers were so much softer than Phainon's own, too damaged to be repaired after one preening session. They were almost silky against his cheek.

"Why not? It's no different than sleeping on my arm. Actually, it's comfier."

Surrounded by spiced pomegranates mingling with Mydei's natural scent as they basked in the sun spot on the floor of their home.

"You're making a mess of our feathers," Mydei grumbled half-heartedly.

"Good thing I already planned to preen yours later."

Mydei sighed and it was a sound of acquiescence, accompanied by the rustle of feathers as his wings folded to cocoon them in. So little light filtered through the few, slitted gaps between their feathers but it was enough to Phainon to watch Mydei's shoulders rise and fall with a deep breath, exhaling the tension that came with his many responsibilities so he could truly relax in Phainon's embrace.

Phainon grinned and shuffled closer, Mydei's arms around his waist holding him tight as he settled again, sharing the same narrow slip of air where he whispered, "Welcome home."

Mydei's brow arched and he answered just as quietly, "You already said that."

A conspiratorial murmur. So the content peace enclosed within their wings could linger undisturbed for as long as they were allowed to have it.

"I know. I like saying it."

"Then…" Mydei smiled and Phainon's feathers fluffed with *joy, embarrassment, fondness* at the pure affection contained within it as Mydei's wing skimmed his cheek in a ticklish caress. "I'm happy to be home."

End Notes

After losing two 50/50s on Phainon's release banner, I have finally managed to upgrade him from E0S1 to E2S1 with only one 50/50 loss.

Then Mydei's lightcone also came home in a 10 pull to make him E0S1, so I decided I had to lock in and finish editing this. It was supposed to be posted yesterday but I was starting to get sick and didn't have the energy to finish up.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!